

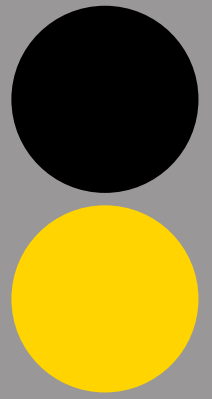


EXPAND YOUR WORLD

GERMAN

LEVEL 1

INTRODUCTION



Course Introduction

Welcome to **German I!** If you're starting this course, it means you are new to the German language or are starting over again to relearn or master previously learned concepts. German is spoken by over 130 million people worldwide, either as a first or second language, making it a very useful world language. It is an official language of six different countries: Germany, Austria, Switzerland, Liechtenstein, Belgium, and Luxembourg. German is spoken in many different dialects across these countries, but the standardized official German is known as Hochdeutsch (High German). In this course, you'll be learning Hochdeutsch, but you'll also be exposed to some of the many main dialects.

This course will start out by introducing you to the most basic and foundational concepts of German. You'll begin to learn the most essential words with short, daily vocabulary lists. Study these words well and learn them as quickly as you can, but feel free to look up words in our recommended online dictionary if you want to know more as you go! Whenever you think of a word you want to use, look it up. These courses do NOT provide you with enough vocabulary to make you know all the words you need to know. We give you the foundation, but part of language learning is self-discovery and experience. This first course of German will introduce you to the language basics. Learn these vital concepts well to build yourself a strong foundation for the more advanced concepts later down the road.

Course Structure

The course is built to be very flexible. The recommendation is to do at least 3 lessons a week self-study, followed by one session a week of instructor-led review & practice. Each lesson follows a very steady format.

Vocab

Each lesson will have a list of vocab. These words are vital to memorize. There usually are no more than 10 words to keep your straight memorization focused on the most essential vocabulary. If you can learn each list each day, you'll gain a great vocabulary quickly. You'll be exposed to more words throughout lesson examples and readings.

It is recommended to utilize some sort of flashcard system to learn these essential vocabulary terms. If you like digital flashcards, we recommend using Anki or Quizlet to make use of their built in spaced repetition. Your instructor can also help you set these up. If you prefer physical flashcards, we recommend researching spaced-repetition using paper flashcards or finding a system that works best for you.

Grammar

Following your vocab lists in each lesson, you'll find a grammar section. This section will cover 1-3 grammar topics each day. This will slowly work in the important things that you have to know while not overwhelming you all at once. This will be, however, the hardest part at times. Remember to ask questions whenever you have them. Also, if you have your instructor lessons, your instructor will make sure to go over all of the grammar (and words) to make sure you understand them.

The grammar sections can sometimes be overwhelming for learners. It is important to remember that your goal is to *learn* these concepts, not *master* them. You do not need to stress memorizing these grammar rules from the get go. As you do self study, you will learn them. When you do instructor-led reviews, you will relearn them. When you see them in use in practice sections as time goes on, you will master them. It is expected that you revisit old lessons to review grammar sections as needed.

Reading

After your first few lessons, you'll begin seeing the reading sections. This will provide a small reading in German (with an English translation) so you can practice learned vocabulary words, gain new vocabulary, watch new grammar concepts being used, and reinforce all that you're learning. Hopefully it'll also clear things up and provide more examples for what you've learned previously. When you read each day, you'll soon notice yourself reading quite a bit of German, and sooner or later, speaking and understanding it.

Pronunciation Guide

Pronunciation is best learned by listening & repeating with real-time feedback. This course does not have a written lesson on pronunciation, but included here is a quick pronunciation guide to use as you study each lesson. Read through the guide now to become familiar with pronunciation rules. Revisit the guide each time you look at your new vocab lists. It is highly recommended to utilize an online dictionary, like Leo Dictionary (dict.leo.org), which includes audio.

A lot of German consonants sound the same as English consonants. In the chart below, we will list the letters that differ. Any letter not included is similar to English.

One important thing to note about German consonants is their **devoicing rule**. This simply means that voiced consonants (b, d, g, v, z) become voiceless sounds (p, t, k, f, s) at the end of syllables. For example, “Tag” which means “day” is pronounced “tahk” because the “-g” becomes voiceless. The spelling doesn’t change, only the SOUND.

Voiced Consonant	Voiceless Consonant
B	P
D	T
G	K
V	F
Z	S

CONSONANTS

German Letter	Pronunciation	Example
Ch- <i>at the beginning of a syllable</i>	If of Greek origin, English “k” If of French origin, English “sh”	<i>Chemie</i> (chemistry) sounds like “keh-mee” <i>Chance</i> (chance) sounds like “shawns”
-ch	After a/o/u, guttural Scottish “ch” sound After e/i/ä/ö/ü/eu/äu, soft hiss sound softer than “sh”	<i>Buch</i> (book) sounds like “bookh” ich (I) sounds like “ish” but soft/hissy
J	English “y”	<i>ja</i> (yes) sounds like “yaw”
Qu	English “kv”	<i>quatsch</i> (nonsense) sounds like “kvatch”
R	guttural “r” like in French produced similar movement as gurgling water no English equivalent	
S- <i>at the beginning of a syllable</i>	English “z”	<i>Sand</i> (sand) sounds like “zant”

St-	English “sht”	<i>stop</i> (stop) sounds like “shtop”
Sp-	English “shp”	<i>Spiel</i> (game) sounds like “shpeel”
Sch-	English “sh” sound (stronger & more rounded lips)	<i>Schule</i> (school) sounds like “shoo-luh”
tsch	English “ch” sound	<i>tschüss</i> (bye) sounds like “choos”
th	English “t” sound	<i>Therapie</i> (therapy) sounds like “tare-ruh-pee”
v	English “f” sound	<i>Vater</i> (father) sounds like “faw-ter”
w	English “v” sound	<i>was</i> (what) sounds like “vas”
z	English “ts” sound	<i>Zoo</i> (zoo) sounds like “tsoh”

When talking about vowels in German, there is an important rule to remember. Vowels in German can be short or long. Sometimes this just means pronouncing them short or elongated, like with “a”, but sometimes it can slightly change the sound of the vowel, such as with “i”.

Short vowels in German are followed by two separate sounding consonants (consonant clusters like “ch” often count as one).

Sand (sand)

Mann (man)

Hund (dog)

Long vowels in German are followed by only one consonant sound. Vowels followed by “-h” are also long vowels. In this case, the “h” is not pronounced but simply signifies the vowel is long. Double vowels are always long.

Bad (bath)

Stuhl (chair)

See (sea)

The letter “e” is tricky, however, as it is used in certain combinations with one consonant, but still remains short. These combos are “-en”, “-er”, and “-el” at the end of a syllable.

VOWELS

German Letter	Pronunciation	Example
a	English “aw” sound (open lips)	<i>kalt</i> (cold) sounds like “kawlt”
	The long “a” is just elongated	<i>Bad</i> (bath) sounds like “baawt”
e	Short sound = English “eh” sound	<i>Essen</i> (food) sounds like “ehs-sin”
	Long sound = English “ay” sound	<i>sehr</i> (very) sounds like “zayr”
	At the end of a word, a single “e” is a short “uh” sound	<i>habe</i> (I have) sounds like “hah-buh”
i	Short sound = English “ih” sound	<i>Pizza</i> (pizza) sounds like “piht-sa”
	Long sound = English “ee” sound	<i>Igel</i> (hedgehog) sounds like “ee-gehl”
o	Short sound = English “aw” with rounded lips	<i>Gott</i> (God) sounds like “got”

	Long sound = English “oh” sound	<i>Sohn</i> (son) sounds like “zone”
u	Short sound = English “uh” mixed with “oo”	<i>Hund</i> (dog) sounds like “hoont”
	Long sound = English “oo” but long & slightly further back in the mouth	<i>Stuhl</i> (chair) sounds like “shtooool”
ä	English “eh” sound as in “bed”	<i>spät</i> (late) sounds like “shpeht”
ö	Make the English “ay” sound with rounded lips	<i>no English equivalent</i>
ü	Make the English “ee” sound with rounded lips	<i>no English equivalent</i>
au	English “ow” sound like in “how”	<i>Frau</i> (woman) sounds like “frow”
ei	English “eye” sound	<i>mein</i> (my) sounds like “mine”
ie	English “ee” sound	<i>die</i> (the) sounds like “dee”
eu / äu	English “oy” sound	<i>Freund</i> (friend) sounds like “froynt”
		<i>Häuser</i> (houses) sounds like “hoy-zehr”

That's it for this introduction to German !! Get ready to be speaking German in no time.

Good luck!